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THE BOARDROOM IS NOW IN SESSION

InnovatingHigherEd.com

Operational Growth Evaluation

Deep Mode | Full 6-Stage Pipeline | All 12 Leaders

Date: February 27, 2026

Pushback & Vision Protocol: ACTIVE

Anti-Yes-Man Rule enforced throughout

Evaluation Type: Operational Growth Evaluation of a live platform

Platform: InnovatingHigherEd.com (refresh at ihe-pulse.vercel.app)

Founders: Dr. Norma Jones (Founder & Host) + Brent Jones (Co-Producer & Technology Lead)

Current Status: Website refresh complete, migration imminent, \$0 revenue, 1,200+ newsletter subscribers

STAGE 1: DISCOVERY COUNCIL

CPV + HMI + HUR

LEADER 01: CPV — Chief Product Visionary

DNA: Jobs × Bezos × Cagan × Spolsky × Chesky

Product Vision Assessment

The Core Question: Is InnovatingHigherEd a content platform, a community, a product company, or a media brand? Right now, it's trying to be all four simultaneously, and that ambiguity is the single biggest strategic risk.

What the CPV Sees

IHE has strong product-market intuition. The Innovation Pulse — a daily curated AI briefing specifically for higher ed — is a genuinely differentiated content product. Nobody else owns this. Inside Higher Ed covers broad news. Enrollify focuses on enrollment marketing. EdSurge tilts K-12. The “daily AI briefing for higher ed practitioners” category is unclaimed, and IHE has planted its flag.

The platform architecture on the refresh site is well-conceived. Six content pillars each serve a distinct user job-to-be-done: Innovation Pulse (keep me informed daily), Podcast (go deep on a topic), AI Directory (help me find the right tool), Prompt Navigator (give me something I can use Monday morning), Tinker Lab (show me what's possible). This is a thoughtful content ecosystem.

Where the CPV Pushes Back (Category A — Structural)

- 1. The product vision is diffuse.** The strategy docs mention premium memberships, online courses, consulting, webinars, community forums, paid newsletters, a virtual summit, book sales, affiliate marketing, and institutional licenses — all as near-term possibilities. This is a two-person team with zero budget. The Bezos framework demands: what is the ONE thing that, if you nail it, makes everything else easier or unnecessary?
- 2. “Educator Tools” is a zombie section.** It overlaps with the AI Directory but isn't clearly differentiated. Kill it or merge it. Seven nav items is one too many.
- 3. The platform doesn't have a product.** IHE currently produces content. Content is valuable but it's not a product until someone pays for it. What exactly does “InnovatingHigherEd Plus” include that's worth paying for? Until you can answer that in one sentence, don't build it.

Where the CPV Builds (Category B — Visionary Opportunity)

The Innovation Pulse IS the product. It's not a feature of the website — it should BE the business model. Think of it as IHE's version of Morning Brew or The Hustle — but for higher ed AI. Those companies were acquired for \$75M+ on the back of a single daily email with a distinctive editorial voice. The Pulse already has the right bones: daily cadence, curated stories, editorial perspective, audio companion, and a clear audience.

CPV Verdict: The platform is strategically sound but operationally overextended. Narrow the focus. The Innovation Pulse is the product. Everything else is supporting content.

LEADER 02: HMI — Head of Market Intelligence

DNA: Porter × Christensen × McGrath × Hamilton Helmer × Ben Thompson

Market Analysis

The higher ed AI market is real and growing. AI usage surged 2.3× in one year, with 93% of faculty planning to expand AI use. Only a third of CIOs feel prepared. This gap between demand and supply of quality guidance is IHE's opportunity. The addressable market: approximately 4,000 degree-granting U.S. institutions employing roughly 1.5 million faculty.

7 Powers Moat Assessment

Power	Status	Assessment
Scale Economies	❌ None	No scale advantages yet
Network Economies	🟡 Potential	Community could create network effects if built
Counter-Positioning	✅ Strong	Incumbents can't narrow to daily AI briefing without diluting brand
Switching Costs	❌ None	Free content has zero switching costs
Branding	🟡 Emerging	Dr. Jones's personal brand has value in CA CC network
Cornered Resource	✅ Strong	Dr. Jones herself — active faculty, AI trainer, institutional relationships
Process Power	❌ None	No proprietary processes yet

IHE's strongest moat is counter-positioning and Dr. Jones as a cornered resource. The problem is neither scales without her. The competitive landscape analysis correctly identifies the gap, but underestimates how quickly a well-funded competitor could enter.

Key Risk: The "1,200+ subscribers" claim needs scrutiny. What's the open rate? Click rate? The HMI cannot render a reliable market traction assessment without engagement metrics.

HMI Verdict: Market is real, timing is right, positioning is sound. Defensibility is thin but buildable through list ownership and portfolio synergy. Speed matters.

LEADER 03: HUR — Head of User Research

DNA: Erika Hall × Steve Portigal × Indi Young × Teresa Torres × Kim Goodwin

User Research Assessment

Primary Concern (Category A): The audience is too broad. Faculty, instructional designers, department chairs, deans, CIOs, and edtech innovators each have fundamentally different needs, consumption patterns, and willingness to pay. Trying to serve all with the same content serves none of them well.

Recommended Primary Persona: Community college faculty who are AI-curious but not AI-expert, teaching introductory courses, with limited institutional AI support. This is the persona Dr. Jones knows intimately and can speak to with authentic credibility.

User Journey Gap: The refresh site is missing a clear user journey for first-time visitors. No “Start Here” experience, no segmentation, and the newsletter signup is at the very bottom of the homepage.

Missing Research: Where are the user interviews? The HUR recommends 10 brief interviews with current newsletter subscribers to validate assumptions before building any premium features.

HUR Verdict: User problem is real. Audience too broad. Narrow to community college faculty. Conduct 10 subscriber interviews within 30 days.

 **GATE 1 VERDICT: GO — Proceed to Stage 2**

Conditions: Narrow primary persona. Declare Innovation Pulse as the primary product. Conduct 10 subscriber interviews. Audit newsletter engagement metrics.

STAGE 2: DESIGN & ARCHITECTURE

CDO + CTO

LEADER 04: CDO — Chief Design Officer

DNA: Jony Ive × Dieter Rams × Julie Zhuo × John Maeda × Mike Monteiro

Design Evaluation of the Refresh Site

What's Working

The Innovation Pulse layout is excellent — the quote block, audio player with waveform, date-stamped editions, and sidebar table of contents communicate editorial seriousness. Content categorization is clear with effective use of tags and badges. The AI Directory cards are well-structured. The About page “What We Stand For” section builds trust.

Where the CDO Pushes Back Hard (Category A)

- 1. The dark theme is a potential alienation risk.** The target audience is predominantly 35-65 year old higher ed professionals who associate dark themes with gaming or developer culture. EVERY major competitor uses light themes. The CDO recommends A/B testing or offering a light mode toggle.
- 2. No photos of the founders on the About page.** In a trust-driven space where Dr. Jones's personal credibility IS the brand, text-only bio cards are a critical omission. Faculty trust people they can see. This is not optional.
- 3. Newsletter CTA is at the bottom of the page.** The “Never Miss a Pulse” signup appears past five content sections. If subscription is the goal, the CTA needs to appear in the first viewport.
- 4. No social proof on the homepage.** No testimonials, no university logos, no podcast guest endorsements. The “1,200+ educators” number is the only social proof element.

CDO Verdict: Strong refresh with real design quality. Dark theme and missing social proof are the two biggest risks. Address founder photos and CTA placement before migration.

LEADER 05: CTO — Chief Technology Architect

DNA: Werner Vogels × Martin Fowler × Kelsey Hightower × Charity Majors × Gene Kim

Technical Architecture Assessment

Next.js on Vercel is a strong architectural choice: SSR for SEO, static generation for performance, React components for interactivity, and zero-config deployment. The WordPress-to-Next.js migration is the right move.

Critical Gaps

1. Content Management: Is Brent manually editing Next.js files for daily publishing? A two-person team needs a headless CMS (Sanity, Contentful) that Dr. Jones can use without touching code. This is the CTO's #1 concern.

2. Email Infrastructure: What platform sends the newsletter? Beehiiv or ConvertKit recommended for newsletter-first strategy — built-in referral programs, sponsor marketplaces, subscriber analytics.

3. Analytics: At minimum: Plausible/GA4 for page analytics plus newsletter engagement metrics. Without data, every decision is a guess.

4. SEO Migration: Proper 301 redirects from ALL old WordPress URLs, sitemap submission to Google Search Console, canonical URL configuration. Losing SEO during migration is costly.

Scalability Roadmap

Phase	Need	Recommendation
Now	CMS for daily publishing	Sanity or Contentful (free tier)
Now	Email platform	Beehiiv or ConvertKit
Now	Analytics	Plausible + newsletter analytics
Q2 2026	Search/filtering	Algolia or built-in Next.js search
Q3 2026	User accounts	NextAuth.js + Supabase
Q4 2026	Payments	Stripe integration
2027	Community	Circle or Discord (don't build)

CTO Verdict: Solid technical foundation. CMS and email infrastructure are critical gaps that must be resolved before migration.

✅ **GATE 2 VERDICT: GO — Proceed to Stage 3**

STAGE 3: BUILD & PRODUCTION

HOE + HQT

LEADER 06: HOE — Head of Engineering

DNA: Joel Spolsky × Robert C. Martin × Jez Humble × Sarah Drasner × Camille Fournier

Bus factor is 1. Brent is the entire engineering team. For a platform promising daily content, this is an operational risk. Document ALL publishing workflows and ensure Dr. Jones can handle basic content operations independently.

Migration Weekend Sprint Plan

Priority	Task	Owner	Time Est
P0	Configure domain DNS for Vercel	Brent	1 hour
P0	Set up WordPress → Next.js URL redirects	Brent	2-3 hours
P0	Test all pages and navigation	Both	1 hour
P0	Verify newsletter signup connects to email platform	Brent	30 min
P1	Add Dr. Jones headshot to About page	Brent	30 min
P1	Add newsletter CTA above fold on homepage	Brent	1 hour
P1	Submit new sitemap to Google Search Console	Brent	30 min
P2	Add social proof elements to homepage	Brent	1-2 hours
P2	Document publishing workflow for Innovation Pulse	Both	1 hour

HOE Verdict: Migration is achievable this weekend. The site is functionally ready. Biggest risk is broken redirects during migration.

LEADER 07: HQT — Head of Quality & Testing

DNA: James Bach × Cem Kaner × James Whittaker × Angie Jones × Tanya Janca

Top Concern: The dark theme creates specific accessibility risks. Body text in lighter gray on dark backgrounds can fail WCAG contrast ratios, especially for users with visual impairments — common in a 40-65 age demographic. A contrast audit of all text elements is required before migration.

The HQT also demands: functional testing of all nav links and interactive elements, SEO migration testing (301 redirects, Open Graph tags, canonical URLs), performance testing (Lighthouse 90+), and security review (HTTPS, CSRF, rate limiting).

HQT Verdict: Needs QA pass before migration. Contrast audit and redirect testing are critical.

 **GATE 3 VERDICT: GO — Proceed to Stage 4**

STAGE 4: LAUNCH & GROWTH

CMO + HOG

LEADER 08: CMO — Chief Marketing Officer

DNA: Edward Bernays × Seth Godin × Binet & Field × April Dunford × Emily Heyward

Repositioning

Current positioning (“AI Innovation for Education”) is accurate but generic. It could describe any of six competitors.

Proposed: “InnovatingHigherEd is the daily AI briefing built by educators, for educators — connecting what’s happening in AI to what matters in your classroom.”

This is specific about format (daily briefing), creator (educators), audience (educators), and value (connecting AI to classroom practice).

Marketing Strategy

- 1. Innovation Pulse as the anchor.** Every marketing effort drives to newsletter subscription.
- 2. LinkedIn as the primary channel.** Higher ed professionals live on LinkedIn. Dr. Jones should post 3-5x/week: Pulse highlights, hot takes, behind-the-scenes.
- 3. Podcast guest cross-promotion.** Every guest has their own network. Create shareable social cards and pull quotes for guests.
- 4. Conference presence.** Dr. Jones should present at every relevant California conference. Each presentation ends with “subscribe to the Innovation Pulse.”

CMO Verdict: Brand positioning needs sharpening. Dr. Jones’s practitioner credibility is the marketing asset. LinkedIn and guest cross-promotion are highest-ROI channels.

LEADER 09: HOG — Head of Growth

DNA: Sean Ellis × Andrew Chen × Brian Balfour × Casey Winters × Lenny Rachitsky

The One Metric That Matters

Weekly newsletter subscriber growth rate. At 1,200 subscribers, 3-5% weekly growth means adding 36-60 new subscribers per week. If growth is flat, nothing else matters. If growth is accelerating, everything else follows.

Top Growth Experiments

#	Experiment	Effort	Impact
1	Add “Forward to a colleague” CTA to every Pulse email	Low	High
2	Create LinkedIn posting template for Dr. Jones	Low	High

3	Create shareable social cards for each Pulse edition	Medium	High
4	Add newsletter referral program (Beehiiv/SparkLoop)	Medium	High
5	Guest podcast cross-promotion kit	Medium	Medium
6	SEO optimization of AI Directory pages	Medium	Medium-High
7	“Start Here” landing page for conference QR codes	Low	Medium
8	Partner content swaps with complementary newsletters	Medium	Medium
9	Submit to newsletter directories (The Sample, etc.)	Low	Low-Medium
10	Webinar funnel: free monthly webinar → email capture	High	High

Growth Projections (Conservative)

Milestone	Subscribers	Timeline	Assumptions
Current	1,200	Now	Baseline
Target 1	2,500	May 2026	3% weekly + LinkedIn + referral
Target 2	5,000	Sept 2026	Compound growth + conferences + SEO
Target 3	10,000	Q1 2027	Viral coefficient >1 + partnerships

At 5,000+ engaged subscribers, sponsored content becomes viable. At 10,000+, the newsletter is a real media asset.

HOG Verdict: Growth infrastructure is underdeveloped. The mechanisms for converting readers into subscribers and subscribers into sharers are missing. Low-effort, high-impact fixes available.

 **GATE 4 VERDICT: GO — Proceed to Stage 5**

STAGE 5: REVENUE

HOS

LEADER 10: HOS — Head of Sales

DNA: Neil Rackham × Matt Dixon × Mark Roberge × Jill Konrath × Aaron Ross

Revenue Prioritization

Revenue Type	Speed to \$	Requirement	Potential	Priority
Affiliate links in AI Directory	1-2 weeks	Add links to existing listings	\$200-500/mo	1 (fastest)
Institutional AI workshops	1-3 months	Package existing content	\$2K-5K each	1 (highest value)
Sponsored Innovation Pulse	2-3 months	3,000+ subscribers	\$1K-5K/mo	2
Podcast sponsorship	3-6 months	Consistent cadence, metrics	\$500-2K/ep	3
Campus AI consulting	3-6 months	Case studies, methodology	\$5K-25K each	2
Premium membership	6-12 months	Platform, content library	\$10-50/mo	DEFER
Online courses	9-12 months	Course production, LMS	\$200-500 each	DEFER

Year 1 Revenue Forecast (Realistic)

Revenue Stream	Q2 2026	Q3 2026	Q4 2026	Year Total
Affiliate links	\$200	\$400	\$600	\$1,200
Workshops (2-3/quarter)	\$4,000	\$8,000	\$10,000	\$22,000
Sponsored Pulse	\$0	\$2,000	\$4,000	\$6,000
Podcast sponsorship	\$0	\$0	\$2,000	\$2,000
TOTAL	\$4,200	\$10,400	\$16,600	\$31,200

Critical Warning: Do NOT launch a paid membership tier before Q1 2027. Faculty rarely pay out-of-pocket. When membership launches, price it as institutional licenses (\$500-2,000/department/year), not individual subscriptions.

HOS Verdict: Revenue achievable in 30 days with affiliates, 90 days with workshops. B2B workshop motion is fastest path to meaningful revenue. Defer all membership plans.

✅ **GATE 5 VERDICT: GO — Proceed to Stage 6**

STAGE 6: DELIVERY & OPERATIONS

HCS + HOO

LEADER 11: HCS — Head of Customer Success

DNA: Nick Mehta × Dan Steinman × Lincoln Murphy × Donna Weber × Mary Poppen

Customer Journey Gaps

IHE has users (subscribers, visitors, listeners) not paying customers yet. The journey from “never heard of IHE” to “evangelizes IHE to their department” has friction at every transition point.

Missing: No welcome email sequence for new subscribers. No engagement tracking. No community mechanisms. No path from individual reader to institutional customer (no “Bring IHE to Your Campus” page).

Recommended Onboarding Sequence

Day 0: Welcome email — “Here’s what to expect from the Innovation Pulse”

Day 2: Value email — “Our 3 most popular resources” (top prompt, top tool, best episode)

Day 7: Engagement email — “What’s your biggest AI question? Reply and tell us”

Day 14: Social email — “Know a colleague who’d find this useful? Forward this”

HCS Verdict: Customer journey exists organically but isn’t designed. Biggest gaps: no onboarding, no engagement tracking, no institutional conversion path.

LEADER 12: HOO — Head of Operations

DNA: Claire Hughes Johnson × Keith Rabois × Shishir Mehrotra × Frank Sliotman × Ravi Gupta

The Brutally Honest Operational Picture

This is a two-person operation where one person is a full-time faculty member with limited hours, and the other is simultaneously building four other AI products. Neither is dedicated full-time to IHE.

Weekly Hours Required for IHE

Task	Hours/Week	Owner
Innovation Pulse (5 editions)	5-10	Brent (production) + Dr. Jones (editorial)
Podcast (prep, record, edit, publish)	3-5	Both
AI Directory updates	1-2	Brent
Newsletter management	1	Brent
Social media / LinkedIn	2-3	Dr. Jones
Site maintenance / tech	1-2	Brent
TOTAL	13-22	

The HOO's Primary Flag: Operational sustainability is the single biggest risk to IHE's success — not strategy, not design, not technology.

Operational Imperatives

Automate: Pulse story sourcing (RSS + AI drafts), social media scheduling, newsletter distribution, analytics reporting.

Systematize: Podcast production workflow, AI Directory review process, guest intake process.

Deprioritize: Tinker Lab (reduce to monthly), Educator Tools (merge into Directory), community forums (defer indefinitely), premium membership (defer to 2027).

Portfolio Priority Stack

1. **IHE** — The audience engine. Without this, nothing else has distribution.
2. **AI OER Platform** — Highest revenue potential. Pre-build stage, can be paced.
3. **AI College Rankings** — Largely built, minimal maintenance.
4. **InnerYoo** — MVP near complete, maintenance mode.
5. **Vibe Presenter** — Longest timeline, can wait.

HOO Verdict: Operationally fragile but viable with automation, batching, and ruthless prioritization. Sustainability is the #1 risk.

 **GATE 6 VERDICT: GO — with operational constraints acknowledged**

FINAL BOARDROOM VERDICT



GO — PROCEED WITH FOCUSED EXECUTION

Three Structural Risks Identified

Risk 1 — Operational Overextension (CPV, HUR, HOO): Too many audiences, too many content types, too few people, too many simultaneous products. Solution: one primary persona, one primary product, one primary metric.

Risk 2 — Missing Revenue Infrastructure (HOS, CTO): Zero revenue and no revenue mechanisms in place. Affiliate links can be added this week. Workshops this month. Sponsored content once the list grows.

Risk 3 — Dark Theme Design Risk (CDO, HQT): The cyberpunk aesthetic may alienate 40-65 year old academics. Testable through bounce rate data and user feedback.

The Board's Top 10 Priority Actions

#	Action	Owner	Timeline	Flagged By
1	Complete website migration with proper URL redirects	Brent	This weekend	CTO, HOE, HQT
2	Add Dr. Jones's headshot to About page	Brent	This weekend	CDO
3	Move newsletter CTA above the fold on homepage	Brent	This weekend	CDO, HOG
4	Add affiliate links to AI Directory	Brent	Next week	HOS
5	Add "Forward to a colleague" CTA to newsletter	Brent	Next week	HOG
6	Build 4-email welcome sequence for new subscribers	Both	Next 2 weeks	HCS
7	Set up newsletter referral program	Brent	Next 2 weeks	HOG
8	Package and promote Faculty AI Workshop offering	Dr. Jones	Next 30 days	HOS
9	Establish Dr. Jones LinkedIn posting cadence (3-5x/wk)	Dr. Jones	Next 2 weeks	CMO
10	Conduct 10 subscriber interviews	Dr. Jones	Next 30 days	HUR

90-Day Metrics Dashboard

Metric	Current	30-Day Target	90-Day Target
Newsletter subscribers	1,200	1,600	2,500
Weekly growth rate	Unknown	3%	4%
Open rate	Unknown	35%+	40%+

Workshops delivered	0	1	3
Revenue (cumulative)	\$0	\$500	\$5,000+
Podcast episodes	~9 total	+2	+6
LinkedIn posts (Dr. Jones)	Unknown	12/month	15/month
AI Directory tools	39	50	75

The Boardroom session is complete. The Dream Team stands ready for follow-up sessions — call the Boardroom when you've completed the 10 subscriber interviews, hit 2,500 subscribers, or need to deep-dive on any stage.

Pushback & Vision Protocol active throughout. Anti-Yes-Man Rule enforced.